Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, without a goal and without trying to make a pretty picture, we often reach for black when we want **a firm mark**, or when we need **silence and depth**. But we do not always know why. Sometimes we know exactly, sometimes not at all. Both are fine.

What may hide behind a black stroke

The same black area on paper can mean **something completely different each time**, depending on what is going on in us. That is why it makes no sense to read a picture like a test with a single right answer.

Strength.

Decisive strokes, a wide brush, charcoal. With one stroke you change something and it shows.

Silence.

A large dark area from which nothing is offered. A space in which one can rest.

Night.

Black with light points or a window. A darkness in which one can dream.

Boundary.

A line that separates and joins. A thin black line can say more than a coloured area.

Sadness.

A dense dark overlay, often over livelier places. Something that cannot be shown yet.

Joy in contrast.

Black on a light ground. The pleasure of there being something to see.

Black in a picture. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, it **can**, but it **does not have to**. A black picture is not automatically a message of misfortune. With black you can paint strength, calm, anger, silence, night and also joy in a striking mark. Sometimes you are attracted precisely by the fact that it does not dissolve into inconspicuousness. The amount of black alone does not determine your mental state. That holds even when black is used by a child.

While working you do not have to decide what exactly it means. Notice the hand, the pressure and whether you want to go on. Meaning comes only in connection with **your experience**.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author's written permission is not allowed.

I want it on the canvas, but I don't dare put it on myself

A picture and a dress ask two completely different things of you. Black in a picture can be quiet and beautiful, and yet you do not feel like going about in all-black clothes. Or the other way round. A peony on paper and a black jacket at a meeting do not rule each other out.

Imagine the same black on three women. On a lawyer, a singer and a teenage girl. For the first you might say "professional", for the second "striking", for the third "what's going on with her?". **The colour has not changed. Your expectations have.**

A black wardrobe is not automatically a sign of sadness, reserve or a strong personality. First of all it is the wardrobe of a specific woman.

When black takes over the space

First, let your hand work. **Black does not have to close anything off.** If you fear it will ruin everything, try it first on a small paper or hold a black cut-out against the picture. You will see the change without having to make it permanent at once.

Three things worth noticing

- **SHAPE**

  A line, an area, or an overlay?

  A thin black line can join or separate something. A large area can create depth, weight and also a protective space. While working you need not decide what exactly it means. Only later can you ask whether the stroke meant a decisive step, relief or just the pleasure of contrast for you.

- **WEIGHT**

  Firm, or too heavy?

  If black feels pleasantly firm to you, leave it alone for a while and watch its shape. If the area is too heavy, open a smaller light place or try a more translucent layer. If everything blends, add a difference of surface, direction of strokes or lightness.

- **COURAGE**

  You do not have to cut in with the biggest brush at once

  Courage in painting does not have to mean cutting into everything immediately. If you want a striking mark, try a wider tool, charcoal or black on a light ground. If you keep covering earlier layers, notice the feeling of covering itself. The interpretation can wait.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

What to take from the picture

It does not matter what a black stroke looks like. What matters is what you feel while making it and what is going on in your life at that moment. **Two identical pictures can have a completely different meaning**. One arose in a feeling of strength, the other after a day when you wanted to hide. That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but **questions**.

A picture can speak even after time

Perhaps later you will link the picture with a period of sadness. Perhaps with a decision that gave you strength. Or you will keep seeing in it mainly a beautiful dark area. In self-reflection inspired by art therapy, what matters is the connection of the picture, your experience and a specific period of life. Black alone does not know your story.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at what you have painted and it tells you nothing. In a week, a month or a year, though, it may suddenly dawn on you. That is fine. **The painting will wait until you are ready to understand it.**

If very strong or painful feelings appear while painting, do not stay alone with them. Talk about them with someone close or with a therapist. This page does not replace professional care.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.